



INTERVIEW | SUBHASH GHISINGH

"I will be happy if Gurung succeeds"

GNLF chairman Subhash Ghisingh spoke at length to Assistant Editor ELORA SEN. Excerpts:

Q. You are not allowed to go to the hills. It is being said that the people don't want you to come back in power.

A. There are security issues. If I go, people will welcome me, but there can be trouble. Thousands died during the 1980s for the cause. I don't want a repeat.

Q. Will you contest the elections for DGHC?

A. First a dialogue has to open to resolve the current crisis.

Q. Why do you think the Sixth Schedule failed?

A. I gave the idea to the then chief minister Jyoti Basu. It could have solved a lot of problems. But the state government kept delaying it. Then it became stale.

Q. You raised the demand for Gorkhaland. Now, if it happens, then Bimal Gurung will be hailed as the leader. How do you feel?

A. I will be happy if it happens, no matter who is hailed as the leader.

That saw an easing of the tension in the hills that had led to bandhs, bringing life to a standstill. But the tension this time did not really affect tourism—the backbone of the economy in this region. The time when Ghisingh had led a rather bloody rebellion in 1980s tourism was badly affected in the whole of north Bengal region and Darjeeling, Kurseong, Kalimpong all suffered for it.

Ghisingh's rise at the state-level and then national-level politics was

meteoric in the 1980s when he emerged as the voice of the Gorkhas—demanding a separate Gorkhaland, representing thousands who wanted to break away from West Bengal and did not want to be treated as second-grade citizens in their own land.

The CPI(M) government headed by the then chief minister Jyoti Basu was able to find a middle path and as a result DGHC was formed and Ghisingh ruled the region for nearly 21 years—

his absolute power was never questioned. In the 42-year-old Gurung, one can almost see a younger Ghisingh—the same do-or-die fervour. "I will not stop at anything less than a Gorkhaland," is his war cry. Once a councillor of DGHC, Gurung fell out with Ghisingh, claiming that the latter did not do enough for Gorkhas while he was in power. He added that it was Ghisingh's fault that even after the burning 1980s Gorkhaland was not formed. He almost calls him a traitor to the cause. "What has he done for the people in the hills in the 21 years that he has been in power?" asks Gurung.

The elder, and now a lot more subdued Ghisingh, however, pooh poohs such allegations. And in a masterstroke tries to defuse talks that he is now, for all practical purposes, out of power in the hills. "I started the demand for Gorkhaland. So if that happens, it is my victory anyway. Anyone who wants Gorkhaland is right. If Gurung is asking for Gorkhaland he is not asking for anything wrong."

Stepping out of his suite in the guesthouse, Ghisingh is ready to answer every question. But when asked whether it saddened him that he could not even step foot into the hills—a region that he had once ruled like an authoritarian king—he evaded a straight answer. "It's nothing. I have no feeling," the 72-year-old said.

The demand for Gorkhaland and the scrapping of the Sixth Schedule has again opened up a Pandora's box. Both the state and the Central governments seem unsure of what the right path is. But Gurung has made his demand clear with both the governments—that he will accept nothing less than a Gorkhaland. With his supporters celebrating in Darjeeling after Ghisingh resigned, the political scene in north Bengal hills will never be the same again. ■

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